SEO CASE STUDY · MARCH TO AUGUST 2026

PIPELINERS · MESA, ARIZONA

REBUILDING SEARCH FOR A PHOENIX TRENCHLESS SEWER CONTRACTOR

Pipeliners repairs sewer, drain and water lines without digging, across 37 cities in the Phoenix metro. In early 2026, Google mostly knew it by its brand name. Over six months I audited the site down to the server, fixed what was keeping pages out of Google, and rebuilt the city pages meant to bring in local jobs. Here is what I found, what I changed, and what the data shows.

CLIENT
Pipeliners
pipelinersusa.com

BUSINESS
Trenchless sewer, drain and water line repair

MARKET
Phoenix metro, Arizona
37 city landing pages

MY ROLE
SEO Specialist, TAG Marketing (agency)

SCOPE
Technical SEO, indexing, on-page, local SEO, schema, content, reporting

STACK
Search Console, Search Atlas (OTTO), PageSpeed Insights, WordPress + Elementor, WP-CLI, Google Business Profile, Claude Code

MAR TO AUG 2026 VS THE SIX MONTHS BEFORE

+46%
Search impressions
124.7k, up from 85.7k in Sep 2025 to Feb 2026

55.7 → 48.2
Average position
7.5 places higher, weighted across devices

72 → 105
Pages in Google's index
Search Console Pages report, June to early September

21 → 43
Mobile PageSpeed
Homepage, Google PSI, before and after the speed work

Clicks held steady: 213 vs 211. Google showed the site far more often, but searchers were not yet choosing it. That gap became the focus in August, and it is the part of this story that is still being measured.

THE STARTING POINT

All the parts of a local SEO program, none of them working together

The site had a service page for each core offer, 37 city landing pages, more than 40 blog posts and an automated SEO platform (Search Atlas OTTO) rewriting pages as they loaded. Pages were missing from Google, several city pages were copies of each other, the mobile homepage scored 21 out of 100, and the automation was quietly overriding edits made in WordPress. Paid search was running at the same time, so every change also had to leave the ad landing pages alone.

DIAGNOSIS

What the audit turned up

Graded the way a sewer camera report grades pipe defects: 5 fix now, 4 fix soon, 3 plan for it.

GRADE	FINDING	EVIDENCE
5	**Almost nobody found the site through a buying search**	About 800 of roughly 927 estimated monthly visits came from the brand name. The 14 transactional keywords the site ranked for drew no traffic. Search Atlas Site Explorer · Jul 2026
5	**City pages were seen but not clicked**	37 city pages earned 6,940 impressions and 1 click in 28 days. 77 queries sat on page one with zero clicks, so the listing was the bottleneck, not the ranking. Search Console · Jul 28 to Aug 24
4	**Real pages were missing from Google**	72 pages indexed and 275 not, including city service-area pages and blog posts. The service-area pages were missing from every sitemap, partly because the SEO platform only crawled the top 100 of the site's 106 pages. Search Console · Jun 2026
4	**City pages were templated, with errors**	The El Mirage page was a copy of the Coolidge page and named the wrong city 23 times. Mesa and Paradise Valley had the same kind of leak. Server audit · Apr 2026
4	**Site hygiene was a liability**	An unrecognized administrator account, a full-site backup sitting in a public folder, and inactive plugins left installed. Server audit · Apr 2026
3	**The mobile site was slow and jumpy**	Mobile PageSpeed 21, layout shift 0.331 (the target is under 0.1) and 66.9 MB of homepage background video. Google PSI · Jul 2026

GRADE	FINDING	EVIDENCE
3	**The automation optimized for the wrong things**	It targeted the Buckeye page at "gas line repair", a service the company does not offer, along with terms like "spring semester". 20 of 107 page titles missed their own page's topic. OTTO audit · Aug 2026

THE WORK

Four phases, each unblocking the next

MAR TO APR

Audit and stabilize

- Ran a full technical audit with server access (WP-CLI over SSH), not just a crawler, and took a full database backup before touching anything.
- Removed the unknown admin account, moved the exposed backup out of public reach, and cleared version leaks and dead plugins.
- Fixed the wrong-city copy on 3 city pages, including the fully cloned El Mirage page.
- Set thin category and tag archives to noindex; turned on breadcrumbs and automatic image alt text.
- Found that the SEO platform rewrites HTML as each page loads, which changed how every later edit had to be made and checked.

MAY TO JUN

Get the pages into Google

- Traced the indexing gap to its cause: the platform's crawl limit kept the service-area pages out of the sitemap. Raised the limit from 100 to 500 pages.
- Requested indexing for the service-area pages by hand while the fix took effect, working within Search Console's limit of about 13 requests a day.
- Published 8 new blog posts, including 6 topic guides with FAQ sections and FAQ schema.

JUL

Speed, a full re-audit and a seasonal content cluster

- Re-encoded the homepage videos from 66.9 MB to 19 MB, turned on safe caching options and stopped the hero image from lazy-loading. Layout shift fell from 0.331 to 0.001.
- Caught a minification setting that made the footer disappear, rolled it back and documented it so it stays off.
- Re-audited the whole site across Search Console, Search Atlas, Google Business Profile and AI search visibility.
- Rewrote titles and meta descriptions for 20 priority pages and verified all 20 live.
- Launched a 7-post monsoon season cluster (a pillar page plus six supporting posts), published July to mid August to match Arizona's storm season.

AUG

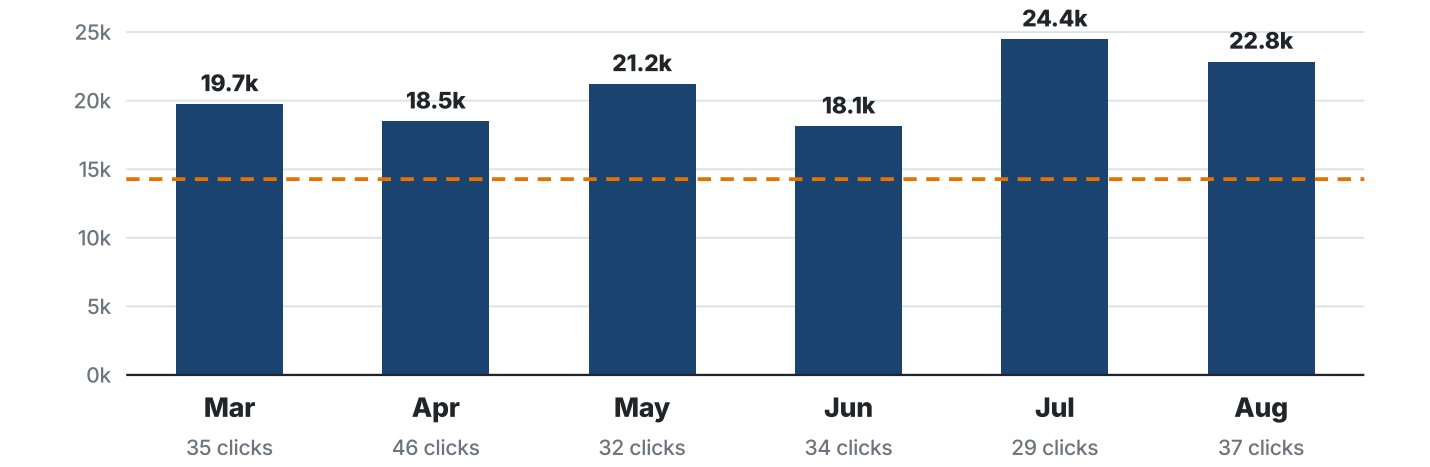
Rebuild the city pages

- Deployed Service and LocalBusiness schema to all 37 city pages using verified Google Business Profile data.
- Moved the last 5 automation-injected FAQs into the pages themselves, so all 37 city pages show the same questions their FAQ schema declares. That removed a hidden 30-question block that broke Google's structured data rules.
- Added 6 to 7 descriptive links on each city page, pointing to the service pages and supporting guides. The main service page went from 35 to 74 internal links pointing at it.
- Audited 131 automated page titles against the live pages, pulled the off-topic gas line terms and paused autopilot so reviewed titles would not be overwritten.
- Locked a clean 28-day baseline, then rewrote titles for the top opportunity pages from page-level query data.

RESULTS

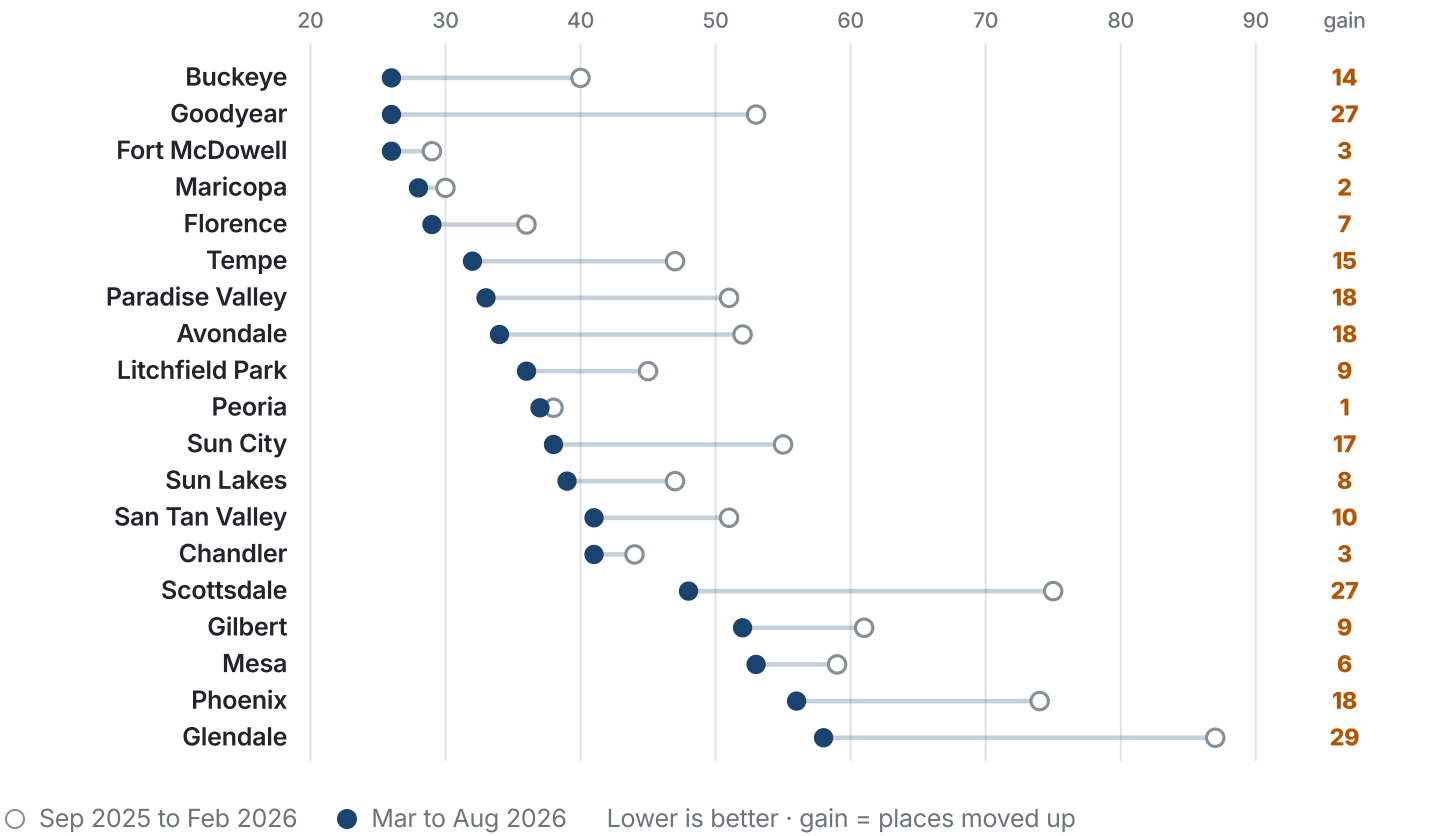
More visibility, better rankings, clicks still to win

Every month beat the prior six-month average



Impressions averaged 20,786 a month from March to August, 46% above the previous six months. Clicks held near 35 a month.

All 19 city pages with 1,000+ impressions moved up



Average Google position per page. Median gain: 10 places. Buckeye moved from 40 to 26 and Tempe from 47 to 32; both are among the pages with the most local demand.

58.0 → 40.9

Mobile average position, with mobile click-through up 47% (0.185% to 0.272%), over the same months as the speed work

35 → 74

Internal links pointing at the main service page after the city-page linking rollout

+27% clicks

First read on matched 28-day windows (Jun 30 to Jul 27 vs Jul 28 to Aug 24): 30 to 38 clicks, CTR 0.146% to 0.191%. Small numbers, so a direction rather than a verdict.

JUDGMENT CALLS

Decisions that mattered as much as the fixes

Turned down traffic the business couldn't use

Buckeye drew 441 impressions for gas line searches. Pipeliners doesn't do gas work, so I removed that targeting knowing impressions would drop.

Withdrew my own recommendation

I had planned a new title for the Florence page. Page-level data showed it already ranked 7th for its main query, so I left it alone rather than risk a regression.

Protected the paid traffic

Before editing, I pulled Google Ads landing-page data: one page took 81 of 84 paid clicks, so it stayed untouched. The same check surfaced zero recorded conversions across all campaigns, which I flagged for a tracking review.

Paused the automation on purpose

Autopilot would have overwritten reviewed titles on its next weekly crawl. I switched it off and documented the cost: new posts now need their metadata set by hand.

Corrected my own read

Comparing a 90-day window with a 28-day one made rankings look like they had collapsed. Re-run on matched windows, position had improved and clicks were up 27%. Every report since uses matched windows.

Verified from outside, every time

Because the automation rewrites pages as they load, I checked each change on the live page instead of trusting the dashboard. Its "deployed" flag and what visitors actually saw did not always match.

LIMITS AND NEXT STEPS

What this doesn't show yet

Clicks are the open problem	Rankings and visibility improved; clicks have not followed yet. The August title and snippet work on the city pages is the response, with re-measurement set for Sep 24 and Oct 22 against the locked baseline.
The click counts run low	These figures come from the https URL-prefix property in Search Console. Clicks on the Google Business Profile's website link land on a tagged http URL that this property can't see, and that link accounts for about half of Google clicks. Reporting has since moved to the Domain property.
Leads need tracking	Google Ads conversion tracking went quiet in late July, so organic leads can't be counted reliably yet. Fixing that is what will tie this work to revenue.

Prepared by Kim · SEO Specialist, TAG Marketing

Data: Google Search Console, https://pipelinersusa.com/ URL-prefix property, all countries, summed across devices, pulled Sep 15, 2026. Prior period Sep 1, 2025 to Feb 28, 2026; reporting period Mar 1 to Aug 31, 2026. Average position is weighted by impressions across devices. City-page positions are Search Console page averages as reported by Search Atlas. Index counts from the Search Console Pages report (Jun 12 and Sep 2, 2026). PageSpeed from Google PSI lab runs on Jul 14, 2026. Seasonal demand differs between the two periods, so period comparisons show direction, not a controlled effect.